WHAT'S IN A PLACE?

When Congress leader Ajay Maken addressed a presser on November 22, 2022 to expose the alleged irregularities in the free electricity scheme of the AAP government in Delhi, more than the subject, the venue attracted attention. Instead of the AICC HQ at 24, Akbar Road, it was held at the Constitution Club. Was Maken not given space because he had dared to offer his resignation as AICC general secretary in-charge of Rajasthan? Party insiders deny any such injunction; it was Maken who apparently chose Constitution Club because he wanted to offer journos some lunch. But AICC HQ has a running canteen where journos often eat. Just saying.

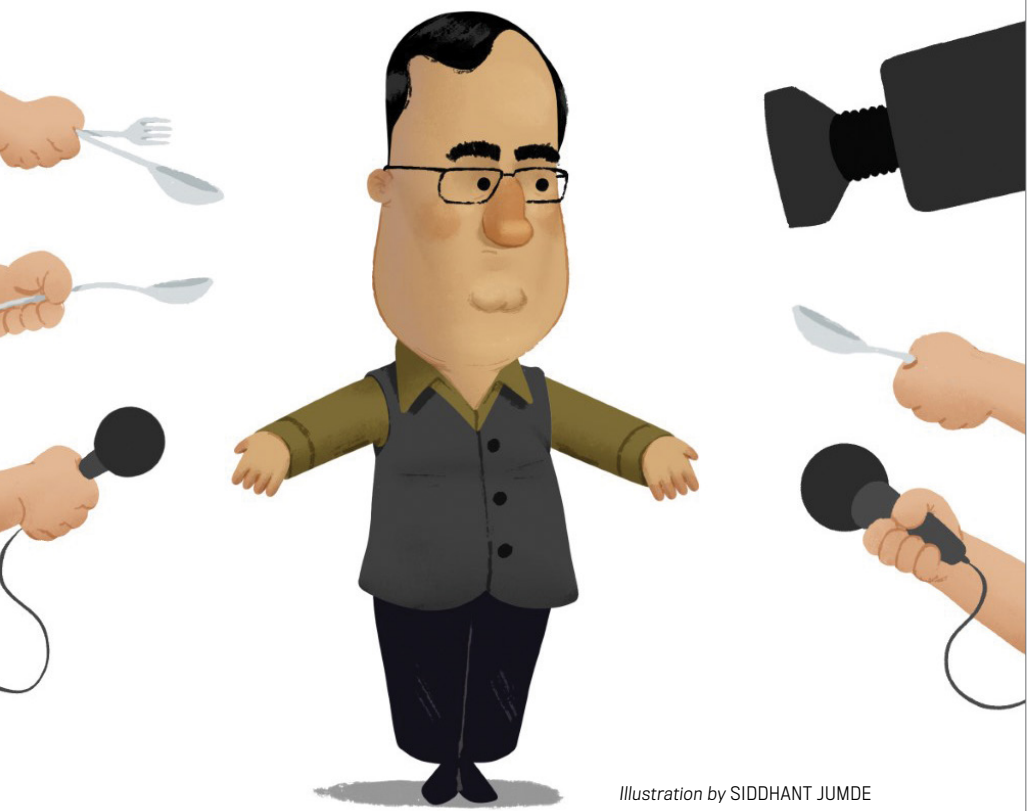


Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

INVECTIVE ATTACK

The Twitter handle of Samajwadi Party's media department is getting a lot of traction these days. But not for its content. The tweets are becoming downright abusive of BJP leaders, and even of local journalists. Ruling BJP leaders are being called *dalal* (broker), *baudambaaz* (foolish), *Aankh ke andhe* (blind). Not all SP leaders are happy as they fear it will hurt the party's image and justify the BJP charge of SP being a *gundon ki party* (party of goons). A senior leader plans to raise it with SP chief **Akhilesh Yadav** though he's amazed he hasn't noticed it till now. Others wonder who's handling the account. Has the job been outsourced to an outsider?



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

Safe Seat-hunting

Congress leader **Siddaramaiah**'s visit to Kolar earlier this month piqued curiosity on whether he was eyeing the southern assembly seat near Bengaluru to contest in the Karnataka polls due in May. While the former CM kept everybody guessing—on whether he will return to home turf in Varuna in Mysuru or stay in current seat Badami in north Karnataka or settle for Kolar—opponents have been taking pot shots at the search for a "safe seat". This week, when the party invited applications from prospective candidates, Siddaramaiah apparently didn't specify any seat, leaving the decision to the high command.



SANDESH RAVIKUMAR

Kaushik Deka with Amitabh Srivastava, Ajay Sukumaran, Prashant Srivastava and Amarnath K. Menon

UPFRONT



Friend to Foe

In July 2017, when Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar rejoined the NDA, he made **Pashupati Kumar Paras**, who was not a member of any house then, a cabinet minister, and sent him to the upper house. Again, when Paras was inducted in the Union cabinet at the cost of his estranged nephew Chirag Paswan in July 2021, it had Nitish's tacit support. No wonder, Paras would heap praise on Nitish. Equations, however, have changed since Chirag joined the BJP camp and Nitish quit NDA in August. Given the nephew's growing proximity to the BJP, Paras has now become a bitter Nitish critic.





WAR OF WORDS

Whether in power or in opposition, politicians in the two Telugu-speaking states cannot stop disparaging each other in public. On November 18, Telangana Rashtra Samithi MLC Shambipur Raju threatened to cut BJP MP D. Arvind's tongue for speaking disrespectfully against their chief **K. Chandrashekar Rao**. The same day, Telugu Desam chief N. Chandrababu Naidu abused and threatened to beat up the protesters demanding the TDP endorse the tri-capital plan. The cheer of the festive season has left politics untouched, it seems.